armed missiles in Cuba without being watched by American airplanes. Khrushchev's gamble seemed to be paying off.[7]

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WITH MCCONE STILL TRYING TO ENJOY HIS HONEYMOON IN France, and little real intelligence to go on, even his own people in the CIA remained complacent with regard to the Soviet buildup in Cuba. The Special National Intelligence Estimate issued on September 19 was anything but alarmist. "We believe," wrote the authors, "that the USSR values its position in Cuba primarily for the political advantages to be derived from it, and consequently that the main purpose of the present military buildup in Cuba is to strengthen the Communist regime there." The authors of the estimate considered the possibility of future placement of Soviet nuclear missiles on the island but thought it unlikely at the moment. "It would indicate a far greater willingness to increase the level of risk in US-Soviet relations than the USSR has displayed thus far, and this would have important policy implications in other areas."[8]

The CIA analysts estimated that Soviet military personnel on Cuba did not exceed four thousand. They counted seventy Soviet ships that had dropped anchor in Cuban ports since mid-July, bringing to Cuba about a dozen MiG-21 jet interceptors, six guided-missile patrol boats, and missiles and equipment for twelve SAM sites that had been spotted on the island. The CIA turned out to be good at counting ships, not particularly good at counting armaments and equipment, and astoundingly bad at counting people. More than forty thousand Soviet servicemen were transported to Cuba between mid-July and mid-October 1962, most of them by mid-September, when the CIA estimate was prepared. Hiding in tween decks for most of their sea voyage to Cuba, they remained invisible to American planes, as were most of their missiles and equipment.[9]

In Cuba extraordinary security measures were taken to conceal the movement of Soviet missiles and equipment to localities chosen by Soviet commanders and their Cuban advisers. The Cuban military and police guarded the ports where Soviet ships unloaded their cargoes, including the